NFL Metric Glossary

Every team-level metric: what it is, in plain language, and why it's tracked.

Generated 2026-10-12 - source: metric_glossary.py

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Team overview

Games played

Games played is just: how many games we're basing every other number on so far.

What it is: How many games this team has played this season.

Why it matters: Tells you how much to trust everything else here - a stat built on 2 games can swing wildly, one built on 10 is much steadier.

Wins

Wins is just: how many games this team has actually won.

What it is: The number of games this team has finished with more points than their opponent.

Why it matters: The most basic scoreboard fact - but a lucky, close win looks identical here to a dominant one.

Losses

Losses is just: how many games this team has lost.

What it is: The number of games this team has finished with fewer points than their opponent.

Why it matters: Same caveat as wins - doesn't say whether the losses were close or blowouts.

Points per game

Points per game is just: how many points this team scores, on average, each game.

What it is: Total points scored this season, divided by games played.

Why it matters: The most basic measure of offensive output - but it doesn't explain WHY the offense is scoring that much.

Points allowed per game

Points allowed per game is just: how many points this team gives up, on average, each game.

What it is: Total points allowed this season, divided by games played.

Why it matters: The most basic measure of defensive output - same caveat as points per game, it's a result, not an explanation.

Point differential

Point differential is just: total points scored minus total points allowed, for the season so far.

What it is: Add up every point this team has scored, then subtract every point they've allowed. A big positive number means they've been outscoring people by a lot.

Why it matters: The single best at-a-glance number for "how good is this team right now" - it rewards blowout wins and punishes blowout losses evenly.

Offense EPA/play

Offense EPA/play is just: on average, are this team's plays moving them into better spots on the field or worse spots?

What it is: Every spot on the field is either good for the offense (close to scoring, or a fresh set of downs) or bad (far from scoring, or a tough down-and-distance). Each play moves the ball to a new spot, better or worse. This number is the average points-value of that move. Example: +0.298 (like San Francisco right now) means their plays are landing them in noticeably better spots than before the snap - worth about 0.3 points on the average play, which stacks up to roughly 15-20 points of edge over a full game. 0.00 is average; +0.15 or better is a genuinely elite offense; -0.15 or worse is a poor one.

Why it matters: Captures whether a play actually helped a team's chances of scoring, not just how many yards it gained - a stat like yards or completions can't tell you a "big gain" happened on 3rd-and-20 and still ended the drive.

Defense EPA/play allowed

Defense EPA/play allowed is just: on average, does the other team's offense end up in a better spot or a worse spot after playing against this defense?

What it is: Same idea as offense EPA, but looking at what happens to the OTHER team's plays when they face this defense. A good defense pushes opposing offenses into worse spots, so for defense you want this number NEGATIVE. Example: -0.133 (San Francisco) means opposing offenses end up worse off, on average, after running a play against them - a good defense. A positive number would mean the opposing offense is winning most snaps against them.

Why it matters: The mirror image of offense EPA - tells you if a defense is actually stopping drives, not just allowing fewer yards on paper.

Offense success rate

Success rate is just: out of every play, how many actually counted as a "good" play for that situation?

What it is: A play only counts as successful if it gained enough yards for the down and distance - roughly half the needed yards on 1st down, more on 2nd, the full distance on 3rd or 4th. It's about consistency, not about big plays.

Why it matters: Shows if an offense is reliably moving the chains, instead of relying on a few home runs to cover for a lot of stalled drives.

Defense success rate allowed

Defense success rate allowed is just: out of every play the other team's offense runs against this defense, how many count as a "good" play for them?

What it is: Same idea as offense success rate, from the defense's side - lower is better, since it means the defense is stopping the other team from getting what they need more often.

Why it matters: Same consistency check as offense success rate, mirrored - a defense can look fine on yards allowed but still be letting the offense stay "on schedule" too often.

Offense yards/play

Yards per play is just: on average, how many yards does this offense gain each time it runs a play?

What it is: Add up every yard gained on offense this season, divide by number of plays run.

Why it matters: A basic speedometer for the offense - but one huge play can make an average day look great, so it doesn't tell steady progress apart from a lucky long touchdown.

Defense yards/play allowed

Yards per play allowed is just: on average, how many yards does this defense give up each time the other team runs a play?

What it is: Same idea, defense side - lower is better.

Why it matters: Same caveat as the offense version - descriptive, but easily skewed by one big play allowed.

3rd-down conversion % (offense)

3rd-down conversion rate is just: how often does this team keep a drive alive on 3rd down?

What it is: Beginner note: an offense gets 4 tries ("downs") to gain 10 yards, or it has to give up the ball. On 3rd down, if you don't gain enough yards for a new set of downs, you almost always have to punt the ball away next. This is the percentage of 3rd downs where this offense got the yards it needed.

Why it matters: The classic "can this team stay on the field" stat - converting 3rd downs keeps possession, runs more plays, and tires out the other team's defense.

3rd-down conversion % allowed (defense)

3rd-down conversion % allowed is just: how often does the other team's offense convert 3rd downs against this defense?

What it is: Same idea as the offense version, from the defense's side - lower is better, since it means more punts forced.

Why it matters: The inverse of the offense stat - a defense that gets teams off the field on 3rd down controls the game clock and gives its own offense more chances.

4th-down attempts

4th-down attempts is just: how many times this team has gone for it instead of punting or kicking a field goal on 4th down.

What it is: Beginner note: on 4th down, most teams punt (kick the ball away) or, if close enough, try a field goal (kick it through the goalposts for 3 points) rather than risk not converting. Going for it means trying to gain the yards needed instead.

Why it matters: Shows how aggressive the coaching staff is willing to be - a philosophy signal, not a quality grade by itself.

4th-down conversion %

4th-down conversion % is just: when this team does go for it on 4th down, how often does it actually work?

What it is: Percentage of 4th-down attempts where the offense gained the yards it needed.

Why it matters: Tells you if that aggression is actually paying off, or just adding risk without the reward.

Takeaways

Takeaways is just: how many times this team's defense has taken the ball away from the other team.

What it is: Beginner note: the defense can take the ball away by catching a pass meant for the other team (an interception) or by recovering a ball the other team dropped (a fumble). Each one is a takeaway.

Why it matters: Half of the turnover battle - every takeaway is basically a free bonus possession handed to this team's own offense.

Giveaways

Giveaways is just: how many times this team's own offense has lost the ball to the other team.

What it is: The same events as takeaways (interceptions and lost fumbles), counted from this team's own offense instead.

Why it matters: The other half of the turnover battle - every giveaway hands the other team a free bonus possession, often the single biggest reason a team loses a game it was otherwise winning.

Turnover margin

Turnover margin is just: takeaways minus giveaways - is this team winning or losing the turnover battle overall?

What it is: A positive number means this team has taken the ball away more than it's given it away; negative means the opposite.

Why it matters: One of the strongest simple predictors of who wins a game - teams that win the turnover battle win the large majority of the time.

Scoring-margin trend

Scoring-margin trend is just: is this team's point differential getting better or worse, week to week?

What it is: Tracks whether the gap between points scored and points allowed has been improving or declining recently.

Why it matters: The "hot streak or cold streak" signal - separate from the season record, it shows which direction a team is trending right now.

Discipline & tackling

Penalties per game

Penalties per game is just: how many times, on average, this team gets flagged for breaking a rule each game.

What it is: Count of accepted penalties (rule violations called by the referees) per game.

Why it matters: A real discipline signal, not just noise - teams that repeatedly flag themselves are giving away free yards and stalling their own drives.

Penalty yards per game

Penalty yards per game is just: how many yards this team loses to penalties, on average, each game.

What it is: Some penalties (like holding, a blocking foul) cost far more yards than others (like delay of game). This adds up the actual yardage lost.

Why it matters: Shows the real cost of a team's penalties, not just how many times they were flagged.

Missed tackle % (whole defense)

Missed tackle % is just: out of every tackle attempt, how often does this defense actually miss?

What it is: Beginner note: a tackle is when a defender brings down the ball carrier to end the play. Missing one lets the offense keep running for extra yards it shouldn't have gotten.

Why it matters: A core defensive health signal - missed tackles are one of the biggest reasons a short gain turns into a long, game-changing play.

Missed tackle % (LBs only)

This is the same missed-tackle idea, but counting only linebackers.

What it is: Beginner note: linebackers are the defenders who line up a few steps behind the defensive line, and handle a mix of stopping runs and covering some pass plays.

Why it matters: Splitting the number out tells you WHICH part of the defense is missing tackles, not just that the defense as a whole is.

Missed tackle % (DBs only)

This is the same missed-tackle idea, but counting only defensive backs.

What it is: Beginner note: defensive backs (cornerbacks and safeties) are the defenders who line up furthest from the line, mainly guarding receivers deep downfield.

Why it matters: Same reason as the linebacker split - pinpoints where the tackling problem actually lives.

Quarterback

Pass attempts

Pass attempts is just: how many times this team has thrown the ball this season.

What it is: Total number of passes thrown, whether completed, incomplete, or intercepted.

Why it matters: Context for every other QB number below - tells you if a rate stat is based on 20 throws or 200.

EPA/dropback

QB EPA/dropback is just: on average, does this team end up in a better spot every time the quarterback drops back to pass?

What it is: Beginner note: a "dropback" is any play where the quarterback goes back to throw, including plays where he ends up running instead. This is the same EPA idea as the team-level version above, just narrowed to only those plays.

Why it matters: The single best all-around number for judging a quarterback's real impact, adjusted for the situation instead of just raw yards or touchdowns.

CPOE

CPOE is just: is this quarterback completing more or fewer passes than expected, given how hard each throw actually was?

What it is: Not every completion is equally hard - a 3-yard pass to a wide-open receiver should almost always work, but a 40-yard throw into tight coverage is much harder. CPOE (Completion % Over Expected) adjusts for that difficulty before judging accuracy.

Why it matters: Separates real accuracy skill from a QB who just throws a lot of easy, short passes and racks up a high completion percentage without actually being that accurate.

Avg. time to throw

Time to throw is just: on average, how many seconds pass between the snap and the QB releasing the ball.

What it is: Beginner note: the "snap" is the moment the ball is hiked to start the play.

Why it matters: Shows the QB's style - quick and decisive, or holding the ball looking for a bigger play - not whether that style is good or bad.

Avg. intended air yards

Intended air yards is just: on average, how far downfield is the QB trying to throw the ball?

What it is: Measures the distance the ball was aimed to travel in the air, regardless of whether the pass was completed.

Why it matters: Shows if this is a short, safe passing offense or an aggressive, deep-throwing one - a style fact, not a quality grade.

Interception %

Interception % is just: out of every pass thrown, how often does the other team catch it instead?

What it is: Beginner note: an interception is when a defender catches a pass that was intended for the offense, immediately giving the ball to the other team.

Why it matters: A real cost number, though it doesn't separate a bad decision by the QB from a ball that got tipped by his own receiver - treat a high number as a flag to look closer, not a final verdict.

Sack rate

Sack rate is just: how often does the QB get tackled before he can even throw the ball?

What it is: Beginner note: a sack is when the defense tackles the quarterback behind the line of scrimmage before he gets the pass off.

Why it matters: Shown alongside the O-line's own numbers below, since a sack could be the QB's fault (held the ball too long) or the line's fault (let a defender through).

Sacks taken

Sacks taken is just: the total count of times this team's QB got tackled before throwing.

What it is: The raw number of sacks taken this season.

Why it matters: Useful, but too rare an event this early in a season to fully trust on its own - pair it with the rate above.

Scramble %

Scramble % is just: out of every dropback, how often does the QB end up running with the ball instead of throwing it?

What it is: Beginner note: a scramble is when the quarterback, unable to find a pass, runs with the ball himself.

Why it matters: A mobility/pocket-collapse signal - shows if a QB likes to run or is being forced to by pressure, not a quality grade by itself.

TD : INT ratio

TD to INT ratio is just: touchdown passes divided by interceptions thrown.

What it is: A fast gut-check on ball security relative to production - above 1:1 means more scores than giveaways.

Why it matters: Raw TD and INT counts don't mean much alone; the ratio between them is the quick version of "is this quarterback helping or hurting more."

O-line / D-line

QB hits allowed

QB hits allowed is just: how many times, all season, has the other team's defense gotten to hit this team's QB - sack or not.

What it is: Beginner note: the offensive line is the group of five blockers whose job is to protect the quarterback and open running lanes. A "hit" counts even if the QB still got the pass off before being hit.

Why it matters: A better protection signal than sacks alone, since it happens far more often and captures pressure even when the play still worked out.

Sacks allowed

Sacks allowed is just: the total number of sacks this team's offensive line has given up.

What it is: Same event as the QB's own "sacks taken" number above, counted from the line's side of the ledger.

Why it matters: Too rare an event alone to be reliable - pair it with QB hits allowed for the fuller picture.

Sacks - QB's fault

This is just: sacks where it was really the quarterback's fault - he held the ball too long or missed an open teammate.

What it is: Determined from actual film charting, not guessed after the fact.

Why it matters: Splits the blame for sacks fairly, using real charted data instead of assuming the O-line is always at fault.

Sacks - O-line's fault

This is just: sacks where a blocker lost his matchup and let a defender through.

What it is: The other half of the same film-charted split as above.

Why it matters: The O-line-specific half of the sack-blame split.

O-line penalties (holding/false start)

O-line penalties is just: how many holding or false-start penalties this team's blockers have committed.

What it is: Beginner note: holding is illegally grabbing a defender to stop them; a false start is moving before the snap. Both are common line penalties.

Why it matters: A discipline signal specific to the five blockers up front, separate from the team's overall penalty count.

Run yards/carry allowed by O-line

This is just: on average, how many yards does this team gain each time they hand the ball off to run it?

What it is: Same measurement as the running back's own yards-per-carry number, viewed here as a line-blocking stat instead.

Why it matters: Cross-reference this with the running back's individual numbers to tell apart "the line is blocking well" from "the running back is just good."

QB hits generated (defense)

This is just: how many times this team's own defensive line has hit the OTHER team's quarterback.

What it is: The mirror of QB hits allowed, from this team's pass-rush side.

Why it matters: Same pass-rush signal as QB hits allowed, viewed from the defense generating it.

Sacks generated (defense)

This is just: the total number of sacks this team's own defense has recorded.

What it is: The mirror of sacks allowed, from the defense's side.

Why it matters: Descriptive pass-rush number, pairs with QB hits generated above.

Run yards/carry allowed (defense)

This is just: on average, how many yards does this defense give up on each running play?

What it is: Same measurement as offensive yards per carry, from the defense's side - lower is better.

Why it matters: A basic, honest run-defense efficiency number.

Pressures generated (player)

A pressure is just: forcing the quarterback to rush, move, or alter a throw, without necessarily sacking him.

What it is: Happens far more often than sacks - a pass-rusher can collapse a pocket all game without ever recording the sack himself.

Why it matters: Catches disruptive pass-rushers whose sack total undersells how much trouble they're actually causing a quarterback.

Running back

Carries

Carries is just: how many times this team has handed the ball off to run it, all season.

What it is: Total rushing attempts this season.

Why it matters: Volume context - tells you how many chances are behind the rate stats below.

Yards per carry

Yards per carry is just: on average, how far does this team get on each running play?

What it is: Total rushing yards divided by carries.

Why it matters: The classic running-back stat, but one long run can make an average day look great - use it carefully.

% carries 4+ yards

% carries 4+ yards is just: out of every carry, how often did this team gain at least 4 yards - a solid, dependable gain?

What it is: The share of running plays that reached a basic "this worked" threshold, regardless of whether it was a huge run or just a solid one.

Why it matters: The real headline running-back stat, not yards per carry - it measures being consistently useful, not one lucky breakaway run.

Explosive run rate (10+ yds)

Explosive run rate is just: out of every carry, how often did it go for 10 or more yards - a genuinely big play?

What it is: The share of runs that broke off a large gain.

Why it matters: Flag it, don't fully credit the running back alone - a big run is often really a defender missing his assignment, which looks identical in the stats.

RB receiving targets

RB receiving targets is just: how many times a pass was thrown toward a running back instead of a wide receiver or tight end.

What it is: Count of pass attempts aimed at a running back.

Why it matters: Shows how much this offense uses its running backs in the passing game - a role signal, not a rushing stat.

Wide receiver / TE

Avg. separation

Separation is just: on average, how much open space does a receiver have from the nearest defender when the ball arrives?

What it is: Measured in yards, at the moment the pass reaches the receiver.

Why it matters: The closest thing to a pure "is this receiver good at getting open" number.

YAC over expected

YAC over expected is just: after the catch, does this receiver gain more or fewer yards than an average receiver would from that same spot?

What it is: Beginner note: YAC means Yards After the Catch - the running a receiver does once he already has the ball in his hands.

Why it matters: A separate skill from getting open in the first place - a receiver can be great at one and not the other.

Total targets

Total targets is just: how many times a pass was thrown toward this team's receivers and tight ends.

What it is: Beginner note: a tight end is a receiver-blocker hybrid who usually lines up right next to the offensive line.

Why it matters: Volume context, not a quality signal by itself.

Team catch %

Team catch % is just: out of every pass thrown to a receiver or tight end, how many were actually caught?

What it is: Receptions divided by targets, for the whole receiving group.

Why it matters: Mixes together QB accuracy, play design, and the receivers' own hands - useful, but doesn't isolate any one of those three.

Drop rate (receiver-charted)

Drop rate is just: out of every catchable pass, how often does the receiver drop it?

What it is: Built from individual receiver charting rather than team totals.

Why it matters: The receiver-side match to the QB's interception rate - closes the loop on who's really responsible when a pass fails.

Air yards share

Air yards share is just: of every yard this team's quarterback tried to throw the ball downfield, what share went to this one receiver?

What it is: Add up every "intended air yard" (how far downfield a pass was aimed, caught or not) for the whole team, then see what fraction belongs to one player.

Why it matters: The cleanest single read on who an offense is actually built around - a receiver can lead

a team in catches without being the real #1 target by design; this catches that.

Avg. cushion

Cushion is just: how much room the defender gave a receiver before the snap.

What it is: Measured at the snap, before the route even starts - a bigger number means the defender is playing further off.

Why it matters: Compare to separation (the room left at the catch): a receiver who gains separation despite a tight cushion is winning with route-running, not just getting a free release from soft coverage.

Secondary

Completion % allowed

Completion % allowed is just: when this defense is targeted, how often does the pass get completed against them?

What it is: Beginner note: the secondary is the group of defenders (cornerbacks and safeties) whose main job is covering receivers.

Why it matters: The more intuitive defensive number, but less precise than yards allowed per target below.

Yards allowed per target

Yards allowed per target is just: on average, how many yards does this defense give up every time it's thrown at?

What it is: Total receiving yards allowed divided by the number of times this defense was targeted.

Why it matters: The real headline secondary stat - it captures actual damage done, not just whether the pass technically fell incomplete.

Interceptions

Interceptions is just: how many passes has this team's defense caught instead of the intended receiver.

What it is: A real, countable takeaway event.

Why it matters: Real turnovers created, shown honestly without a fuller "total disruption" number, since that fuller data isn't available yet.

Pressures generated

Pressures generated is just: how many times this defense forced the QB to rush his throw or scramble, whether or not it ended in a sack.

What it is: A broader pass-rush count than sacks alone.

Why it matters: Most good pass-rush plays never actually end in a sack, so this catches disruption that sacks alone would miss.

Passes defended (PBU)

A pass breakup is just: a defender knocking down or deflecting a catchable pass without intercepting it.

What it is: Charted separately from interceptions - the ball never changes possession, but the defender still did their job.

Why it matters: Often a better read on coverage skill than interceptions, which depend on a bit of luck (the ball has to bounce to the defender, not just away from the receiver).

Forced fumbles

A forced fumble is just: a defender knocking the ball loose from the ball-carrier.

What it is: A separate skill from recovering it - the strip and the recovery are often two different players.

Why it matters: A real defensive-disruption stat distinct from interceptions - stripping the ball creates a turnover even when the defender isn't the one who ends up with it.

Fumble recoveries

A fumble recovery is just: being the player who ends up with the ball after it's knocked loose.

What it is: Can happen on a ball this same player forced, or one a teammate forced - it's charted as its own event.

Why it matters: Pair with forced fumbles to see who's actually around the ball when it comes out, not just who causes it to come out.

Combined tackles

Combined tackles is just: solo tackles plus assisted tackles, added together.

What it is: The standard raw counting stat for "how often was this player involved in bringing the ball-carrier down."

Why it matters: Best read alongside a missed-tackle rate - high volume alone rewards being near the ball constantly, not necessarily finishing plays cleanly.

Special teams

Field goal % (overall)

Field goal % is just: out of every field goal try, how many go in?

What it is: Beginner note: a field goal is a kick through the goalposts worth 3 points, usually attempted on 4th down when a touchdown looks unlikely.

Why it matters: Small sample early in a season - read it together with how many attempts it's based on.

Punt net average

Punt net average is just: how far does this team's punt actually flip the field, after subtracting any yards the other team returned it?

What it is: Beginner note: a punt is a kick, usually on 4th down, that gives up the ball but pushes it far down the field. A "return" is the other team running the ball back after catching it.

Why it matters: The real "did this help my team" number - a long punt that gets run back 40 yards didn't actually help much.

Kickoff net average

Kickoff net average is just: same idea as punt net average, but for the kick that starts each half and follows a score.

What it is: Kickoff distance, net of any return yardage.

Why it matters: Same real-field-position logic as punt net average, applied to kickoffs.

Punt return yards gained

Punt return yards gained is just: total yardage gained on punt returns, added up across the season.

What it is: A quieter field-position weapon that mostly only gets attention when it produces a long return or a touchdown.

Why it matters: Hidden value - good punt-return yardage shortens the field for the offense all game, not just on the highlight play.

Play-type tendency

Play-action %

Play-action % is just: how often does this team fake a handoff before throwing, to trick the defense?

What it is: Beginner note: play-action is when the QB fakes handing the ball to a running back, then throws instead, hoping the fake pulled defenders out of position.

Why it matters: An offensive-identity signal, meant to be checked against how well the offense is actually performing rather than judged alone.

RPO %

RPO % is just: how often does this offense run a play where the QB decides to hand off OR throw AFTER the snap, based on what the defense does?

What it is: Beginner note: RPO stands for "run-pass option" - a modern play design that keeps the defense guessing by giving the QB a live decision after the ball is snapped.

Why it matters: A modern-offense identity marker.

Screen pass %

Screen % is just: how often is this offense throwing a short, quick pass with blockers already running out in front of the receiver?

What it is: Beginner note: a screen pass is designed to look like a normal dropback at first, then dumps the ball off quickly behind a wall of blockers.

Why it matters: Screens inflate completion % and shrink average throw distance - good context for both of those other numbers.

No-huddle %

No-huddle % is just: how often does this offense skip huddling up and run plays quickly, back to back?

What it is: Beginner note: normally a team huddles (gathers briefly) between plays to call the next one - no-huddle skips that to play faster.

Why it matters: A tempo/identity marker, not a quality signal on its own.

Pre-snap motion %

Pre-snap motion % is just: how often does this offense shift a player around before the snap?

What it is: Beginner note: motion is a player moving from his starting spot right before the ball is snapped, often to reveal what defense is being played.

Why it matters: One of the clearest modern-offense identity markers in today's league.

Drop rate (play-charted)

This is just: a second way of measuring how often this offense's passes get dropped, based on film charting instead of receiver stats.

What it is: Computed from play-by-play charting rather than the individual receiver totals used for the

drop rate above.

Why it matters: A different computation lens than the receiver-charted drop rate - both are real, worth comparing rather than assuming one is "correct."

Play-action faced %

Play-action faced % is just: how often do opposing offenses fake a handoff before throwing, when they play against this defense?

What it is: Same play-action tag as the offense version above, but grouped by the team ON DEFENSE - this is what a defense typically sees thrown at it, not what its own offense does.

Why it matters: A defensive-identity signal - a defense that faces a lot of play-action a lot might be one offenses think they can freeze with run fakes.

RPO faced %

RPO faced % is just: how often do opposing offenses run a run-pass-option play against this defense?

What it is: Same RPO tag as the offense version, grouped by the team on defense instead.

Why it matters: Shows whether opponents are using modern run-pass-option looks to attack this defense specifically.

Screen faced %

Screen faced % is just: how often do opposing offenses throw a screen pass against this defense?

What it is: Same screen tag as the offense version, grouped by the team on defense instead.

Why it matters: A defense that faces a lot of screens is often one opponents think is easy to out-athlete or too aggressive up front.

No-huddle faced %

No-huddle faced % is just: how often do opposing offenses skip huddling and play fast against this defense?

What it is: Same no-huddle tag as the offense version, grouped by the team on defense instead.

Why it matters: Shows if opponents are trying to tire this defense out or catch it before it can substitute.

Motion faced %

Motion faced % is just: how often do opposing offenses shift a player before the snap against this defense?

What it is: Same motion tag as the offense version, grouped by the team on defense instead.

Why it matters: A defense that faces heavy motion is one opponents are trying to confuse before the ball is even snapped.

Drop rate faced (play-charted)

This is just: how often do opposing offenses' passes get charted as drops when playing against this defense.

What it is: Same play-charted drop tag as the offense version, grouped by the team on defense instead.

Why it matters: Descriptive - a defense forcing a lot of drops may be applying real pressure or hits as the ball arrives, or it may just be facing shaky-handed receivers.

Blitz rate

Blitz rate is just: out of every real pass-rush situation, how often does this defense send extra rushers instead of dropping back into coverage?

What it is: Beginner note: a blitz is sending more pass rushers than the defense normally would, to pressure the QB faster, usually at the cost of one fewer defender in coverage. Real FTN charting, restricted to plays where pass-rush was actually charted (not every play has this recorded).

Why it matters: A real defensive-scheme identity marker - a genuine measure of how aggressive a defensive coordinator is, not a proxy or a guess.

Avg. blitzers sent

This is just: on average, how many extra rushers does this defense send on a real pass-rush play?

What it is: The count behind the blitz rate above - 0 means standard rush, higher means more aggressive extra pressure.

Why it matters: Pairs with blitz rate to show not just how OFTEN a defense blitzes, but how HARD it blitzes when it does.

Avg. total pass rushers

This is just: on average, how many total defenders rush the passer on a real pass-rush play (standard rush plus any blitzers)?

What it is: A real, charted count - a standard NFL rush is usually 4; anything higher reflects blitz packages.

Why it matters: The full picture behind blitz rate - shows the actual rush numbers a QB has to read, not just whether it counts as a "blitz."

Stacked-box rate

Stacked-box rate is just: out of every play where box count was charted, how often does this defense put 8 or more defenders near the line to stop the run?

What it is: Beginner note: the "box" is the area right around the line of scrimmage where run-stopping defenders line up. Loading it up (a "stacked box") commits extra defenders to stopping the run, at the cost of pass coverage.

Why it matters: A real run-defense scheme signal - a defense stacking the box a lot is committing hard to stopping the run, which an offense can exploit through the air if it notices.

Avg. box defenders

This is just: on average, how many defenders does this defense keep near the line of scrimmage?

What it is: The count behind stacked-box rate - a typical defense runs 6 or so; higher means more committed to stopping the run on average.

Why it matters: Cross-reference with RB "% carries vs. stacked box" on the RB tab - a defense that loads the box a lot should show up there too from the offense's side.

Pressure rate - natural rush

This is just: on the plays where this defense rushed the passer WITHOUT sending extra blitzers, how often did it actually get a QB hit or sack?

What it is: Same real per-play charting (blitz flag) cross-referenced with the real per-play QB-hit/sack outcome, restricted to non-blitz pass-rush plays.

Why it matters: The D-line's own pressure number, isolated from blitz help - tells you how good the front four (or however many) really are on their own.

Pressure rate - blitzing

This is just: on the plays where this defense sent extra blitzers, how often did it actually get a QB hit or sack?

What it is: Same cross-reference as above, restricted to plays where at least one extra rusher was sent.

Why it matters: Compare directly to the natural-rush number - if blitzing barely raises the pressure rate, the blitz may be more about disguise/pressure-on-paper than real production, or the reverse if it raises it a lot.